

Cost of a Healthy Diet in Ghana

2025 Quarter 2 Bulletin

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Highlights

- The Cost of a Healthy Diet (CoHD) refers to the least-expensive combination of available foods that meet the daily nutritional requirements outlined in Ghana's food-based dietary guidelines. It serves as an indicator of both physical and economic access to healthy diets.
- In the second quarter of 2025, the national average CoHD stood at GH¢14.80, representing a 0.7% decline compared to the first quarter of the year.
- The highest CoHD during the second quarter, 2025 reference period was recorded in the Western Region, at GH¢23.05.
- Animal source foods and vegetables made up the largest share of the total diet cost, accounting for 28% and 25% respectively.

Data Collection and Methodology

In Ghana, the Cost of a Healthy Diet (CoHD) represents the minimum cost of foods required to meet the daily nutritional goals outlined in the country's food-based dietary guidelines. These guidelines categorize food into six groups: starchy staples; legumes, nuts, and seeds; vegetables; fruits; oils and fats; and animal source foods.

The retail price data used in this analysis was collected by the Statistics, Research and Information Directorate (SRID) of the Ministry of Food and Agriculture (MoFA). Data was gathered from 185 markets across 14 regions of Ghana on a weekly basis, and regional averages were computed at the end of each month. Central and North East Region were excluded from this bulletin due to lack of data. In total, 76 food commodities were monitored by MoFA, as detailed in Table 1.

Table 1: Quantified food-based dietary guidelines for Ghana

Food Group	No. of Foods Recommended	Calories Needed (kcal/day)	Share of calories (%)	No. of Items in MoFA Food List
Starchy staples	2	1191	51	21
Oils and fats	1	50	2	3
Vegetables	3	109	5	16
Fruits	2	147	6	10
Legumes nuts and seeds	2	591	25	11
Animal source foods	2	243	10	15
Total	12	2,330	100	76

Cost of a Healthy Diet

The Cost of Healthy Diet (CoHD) is the cost of the least expensive combination of food that meets the healthy diet recommendation. The National Average CoHD for the second quarter per person per day for 2025 was Gh¢14.80, a reduction of 0.7% from Gh¢14.91 in the first quarter of 2025 (Figure 1).

Regional Average Cost of a Healthy Diet

In the second quarter of 2025, the regional average CoHD in Ghana generally declined compared to the first quarter. However, Western and Oti regions experienced an upward trend of 7.1% and 12.3% respectively. A regional comparison showed that the Western region recorded the highest CoHD at GH¢23.05, while the Ahafo region had the lowest at GH¢9.27 (see Table 2). The most significant decreases occurred in the Volta (-16.7%), Savannah (-11.5%) and Northern (-8.7%) regions, whereas the Bono East region experienced the least decrease (-0.1%).

Figure 1: Average Cost of a Healthy Diet and quarter-on-quarter change by region

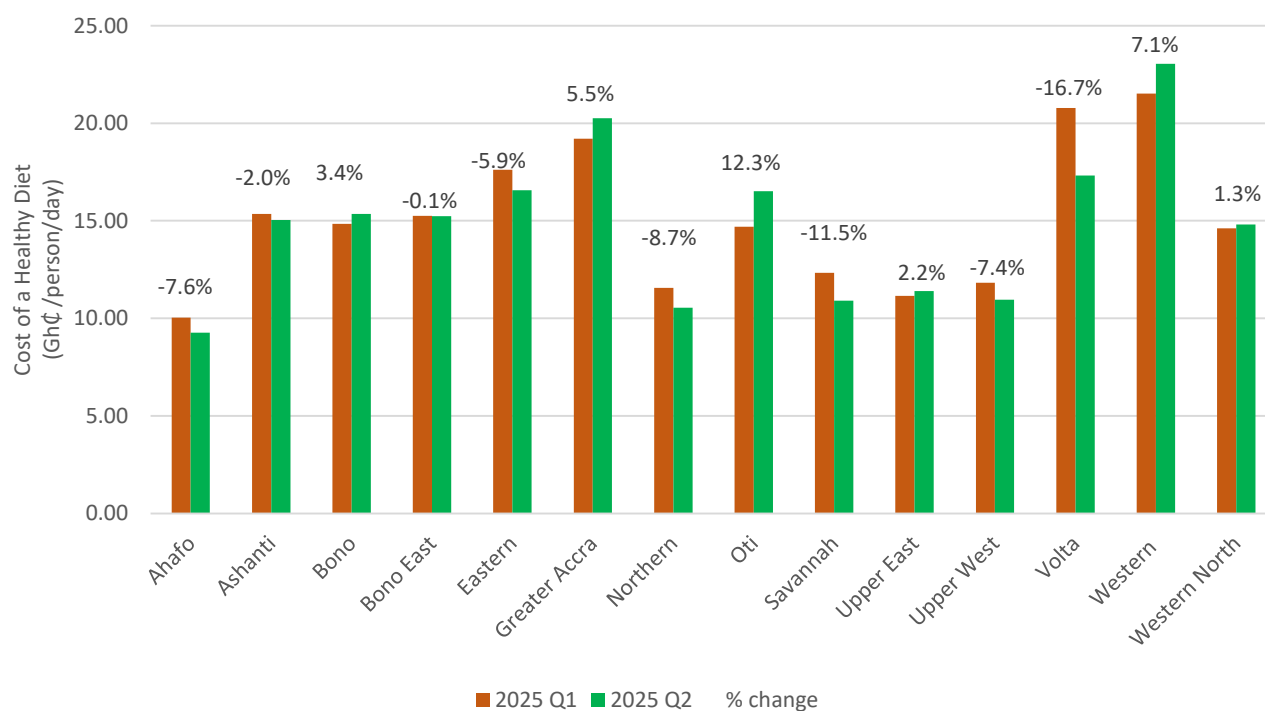


Table 2: Average Cost of a Healthy Diet by region

Regions	2025 Q1	2025 Q2	% change
Ahafo	10.03	9.27	↓ -7.6%
Ashanti	15.35	15.05	↓ -2.0%
Bono	14.85	15.35	↑ 3.4%
Bono East	15.25	15.23	↓ -0.1%
Eastern	17.61	16.57	↓ -5.9%
Greater Accra	19.21	20.26	↑ 5.5%
Northern	11.56	10.55	↓ -8.7%
Oti	14.70	16.51	↑ 12.3%
Savannah	12.33	10.91	↓ -11.5%
Upper East	11.15	11.40	↑ 2.2%
Upper West	11.83	10.95	↓ -7.4%
Volta	20.78	17.32	↓ -16.7%
Western	21.53	23.05	↑ 7.1%
Western North	14.61	14.81	↑ 1.3%
National average	14.91	14.80	↓ -0.7%

Cost Share by Food Group

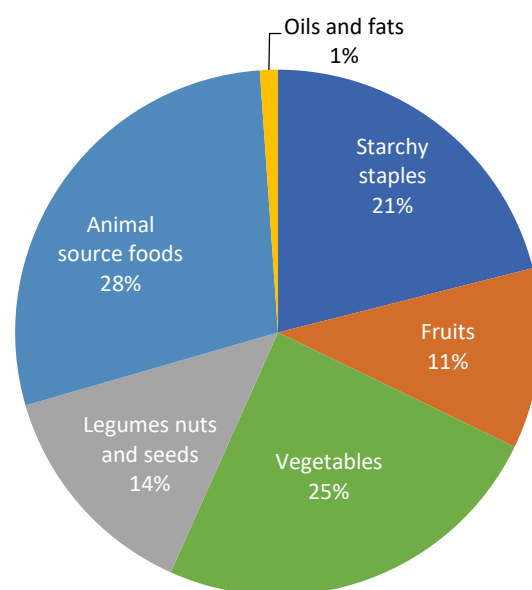
The cost share by food group seeks to determine the average cost of each food group and to determine which food group cost the highest. The cost share per food group and the shared calories can vary depending on various factors

such as geographical location, season and market dynamics.

As seen in figure 2, vegetables account for one-quarter of the daily among all food groups, representing 25% of the total CoHD, despite making up only 5% of the recommended calorie share (see Table 1). Animal source foods had the highest cost share, accounting for 28% of the total diet cost and only 10% of the recommended calorie share.

Fruits registered only 11% of the daily cost, and starchy staples which have the highest share of recommended calories represents 21% of the total cost. This trend was similar for all 14 regions.

Figure 2: National average food group cost share

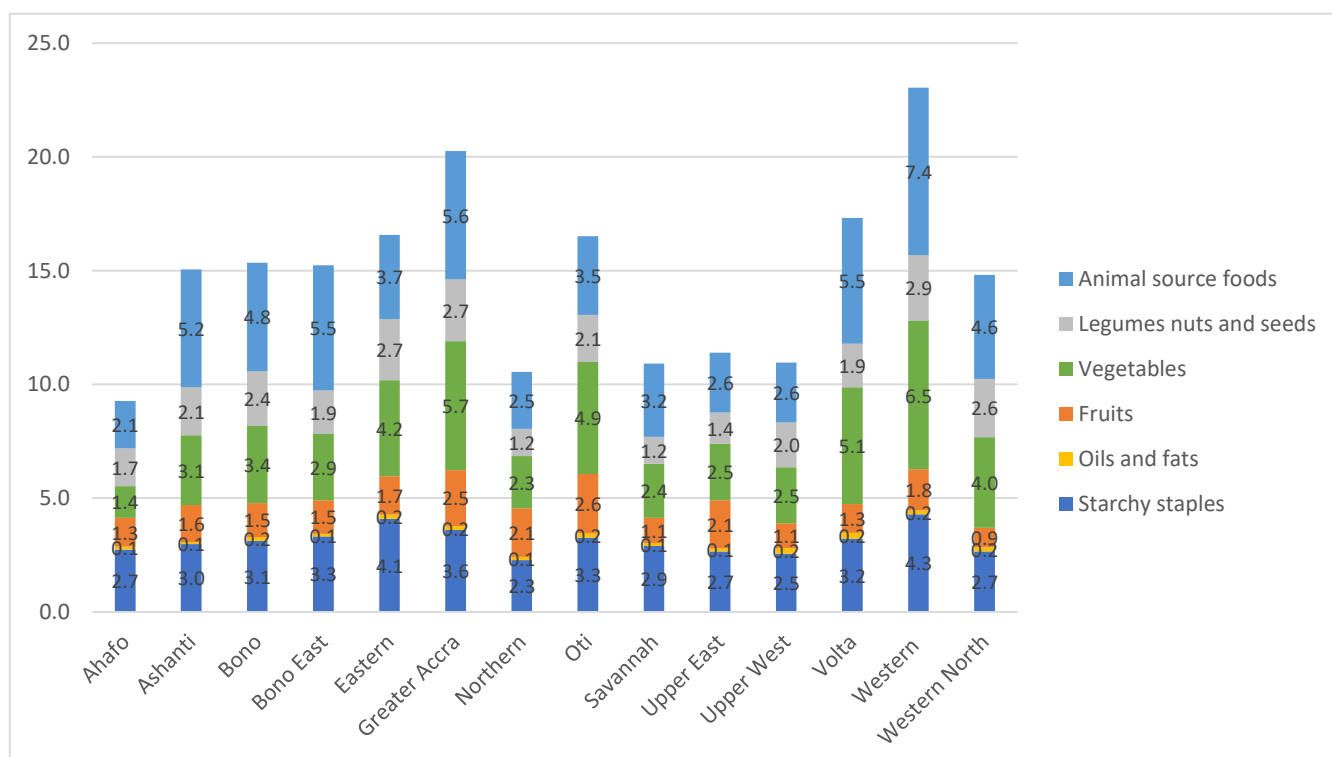


Regional Distribution of Cost Share by Food Group

On regional basis, Western reported the highest daily cost of vegetables at an average cost of Gh¢6.5, whilst Ahafo region recorded the least expensive daily cost of vegetables (Gh¢1.4).

For legumes, nuts and seeds, Western region also had the highest daily cost of Gh¢2.9. Additionally, comparative analysis on fruits, revealed that Oti region, recorded the highest daily cost of Gh¢2.6. For animal source foods, Western region recorded the highest daily cost of Gh¢7.4.

Figure 3: Food group cost, by region



Frequently Selected Commodities in each Food Group

The Cost of a Healthy Diet can be determined based on the price of each food item at each time and place, hence the least-cost items selected may vary across regions and months of the year. Within the vegetable food group, alefu (*Amaranthus*) and dried okro recorded the highest percentage of least cost vegetable that was selected in the second quarter of 2025 each at 28% of the selections.

For starchy staples, white maize was the most frequently selected item, featuring 40% of least-cost diets, closely followed by dried cassava chips at 39%. Palm oil was the most frequently selected type of oil (67%) while groundnut oil was the least selected (14%). Among legumes, nuts and seeds, soybeans were in 33% of least-cost diets. Bambara beans was ranked as least commonly selected at 1%.

Avocado Pear was the most frequently selected in the fruit category at 37% and Coconut (Fresh) was the second most frequently selected at 17%. Within the animal source food, Kako was recorded as the most selected animal source at 26%.

Table 3. Frequently selected least-cost items

Food Group	Commodity	Number of times selected as least-cost	% of least-cost diets that include food as a least-cost item
Starchy staples	Maize (White)	34	40%
	Dried Cassava Chips (Kokonte)	33	39%
	Maize (Yellow)	8	10%
Oils and fats	Palm Oil	28	67%
	Coconut Oil	8	19%
	Groundnut Oil	6	14%
Fruits	Avocado Pear	31	37%
	Coconut (Fresh)	14	17%
	Mango (Local)	13	15%
Vegetables	Alefu (<i>Amaranthus</i>)	35	28%
	Okro (Dried)	35	28%
	Nkontomire	19	15%
Legumes nuts and seeds	Soya Bean	28	33%
	Groundnut (Red)	26	31%
	Unshelled Groundnut	11	13%
Animal source foods	Kako	22	26%
	Salted Dried Tilapia (Koobi)	17	20%
	Anchovy	11	13%

Availability

Most of the food items were available in almost all regions during the second quarter, with only a few exceptions that were missing during some months. Fresh cow milk was only available in 33.33% (16 of 48) of region- month combinations, snail was only available in 37.5% (18 of 48). Also, sweet potato (general: white and pinkish) was available only in 43.75% (21 of 48) of the region-month combination during Q2 2025. These items are rarely selected as least cost therefore their unavailability is not likely to affect access to healthy diets for the most vulnerable.

Factors that affect demand include cultural preferences and tastes as well as the availability and unavailability of specific commodities in certain regions. For example, there is less motivation to distribute snails in certain regions such as the Northern part of Ghana where they are viewed as a taboo to consume it.

Relative Changes in the Consumer Price Indices and CoHD

The Consumer Price Index (CPI) is a tool used to measure inflation, which is the average change over time in the prices of goods and services that are consumed by people for their daily needs. Figures 4 and 5 compare the national general CPI and the food CPI calculated by the Ghana Statistical Service, with the Cost of a Healthy Diet. Figure 4 compares the general CPI and the food CPI (indices with 2021 as the base year) with the nominal Gh¢ value of the Cost of a Healthy Diet, to understand whether the least-cost items needed for a healthy diet are rising in cost at a rate like that of the rest of the goods and services in Ghana. Food prices and the CoHD are both expected to rise over time; here we focus on the relative rate of that inflation.

The food CPI includes a larger number of items, and more packaged and value-added items than the CoHD, as least-cost items are often relatively unprocessed foods. Over time, all three indicators - the CoHD, general CPI, and food CPI have shown a steady increase. However, figure 5 shows the relative change over the past year. Although all three indicators continued to show a steady increase, the rate of increase of the CoHD was lower than that of the CPI.

Figure 4: Relative Changes in CPI and CoHD (Value)

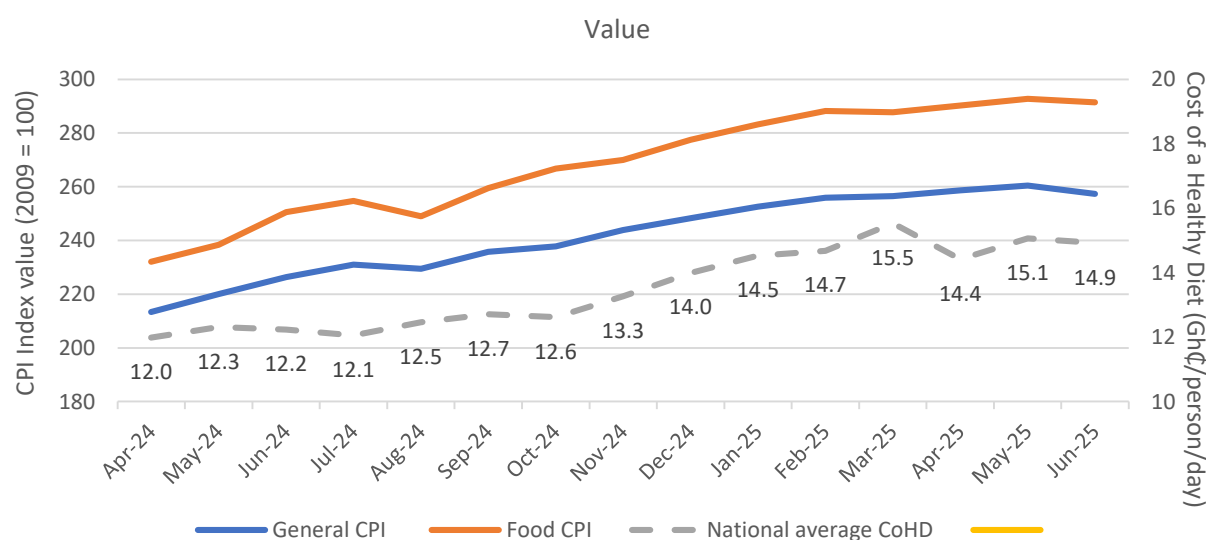
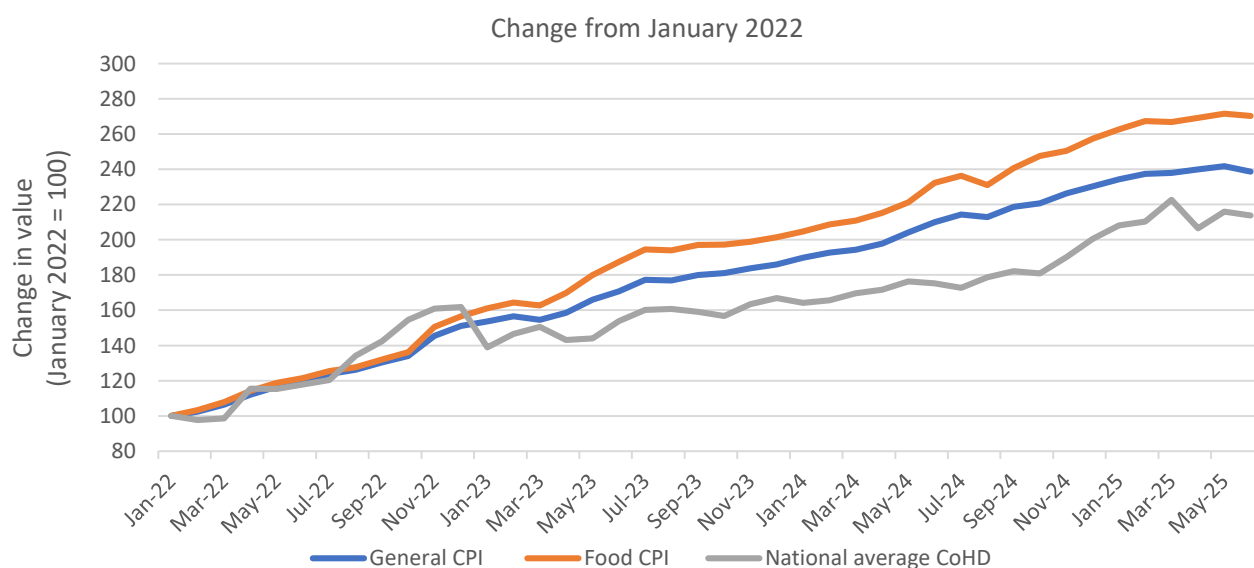


Figure 5: Relative Changes in CPI and CoHD



Policy Implications

The Cost of a Healthy Diet (CoHD) affects an individual's ability to have access to quality food. Analysing the CoHD have positive implications for addressing food security challenges in Ghana. Here are some potential strategies based on policy.

The Ministry of Food and Agriculture's goals are targeted to mitigate the high cost of healthy diets and to ensure that quality diet is accessible to all. This cannot be effectively achieved without estimating the CoHD. Among the objectives of the National Medium-Term Development Policy Framework (NMTDPF) that are relevant to the ministry are:

- Improve public-private investments in the agricultural sector,
- Modernize and enhance agricultural production systems,
- Improve post-harvest losses and promote agriculture as a viable business among the youth,
- and promote livestock and poultry development.

Achieving the objectives of the NMTDPF can lead to more efficient and productive agricultural sector which can ultimately reduce the cost of healthy diet for consumers and translate to better public health outcomes by making healthy diets more accessible and affordable.

The implementation of the Feed Ghana Programme (FGP) is expected to address the above objectives.

Again, one way to improve food systems is by allocating resources to commodities for agricultural production and implementing trade and other policy interventions. Strengthening programs like the Outgrower and Value Chain Fund (OVCF) is essential for providing medium to long-term financing to agricultural value chain players, including commercial farmers. Currently, OVCF focuses on rubber, oil palm, rice, pineapple, maize-soya-sorghum, cassava-gari, cocoa, and poultry-maize schemes. Extending funding to vegetables such as tomato, onion and pepper will bring some relief as these vegetables are important ingredients in most diets in Ghana. This support can facilitate investment in productivity-enhancing measures and infrastructure, ultimately improving food availability.

It is essential to comprehend the minimum income required by households to afford a healthy diet. This knowledge is crucial for developing effective social protection and transfer programs such as Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) for vulnerable populations. Policymakers can utilize this pertinent data to establish appropriate income thresholds such as setting the minimum wage and target interventions where they are most needed.

Support for the bulletin

This bulletin is produced by SRID-MoFA, with technical support from Food Prices for Nutrition project at Tufts University. For questions or comments, please email james.ayittey@mofa.gov.gh or eunice.arhin@mofa.gov.gh.